Lesson 34: The APA Research Report 1: Title Page, Abstract and Introduction

English Stage 4 (Psychology) · Unit 5: Writing and Presenting Research in APA Style

Adapted from Research Methods in Psychology (4th American edition) by Rajiv S. Jhangiani, I-Chant A. Chiang, Carrie Cuttler and Dana C. Leighton (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 11.3 Writing a Research Report in American Psychological Association (APA) Style (from "Sections of a Research Report" to the end of "Introduction"); exercises from 11.5 Presenting Your Research (Summary).

In this lesson

In the first of two lessons on the APA-style research report, you study the title page, the abstract and the introduction (Lesson 35 covers the rest). In English, you practise titles built from noun phrases, sentences that link the steps of an argument, and a precise statement of a hypothesis.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Write a title that names the main variables, and set up a 7th-edition student title page.
- Say what an abstract contains and where it goes.
- Identify the opening, literature review and closing of an introduction, and explain the job of each.
- Write a balanced literature review with linking paragraph openings, and a precise closing.

Key language

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
empirical research report	a journal article in which the author reports on a new empirical research study	Darley and Latané (1968)
title page	the first page of an APA-style manuscript: title, author names and affiliations, author note	no author note in student papers
affiliation	the institution where the authors worked when they did the research	California State University, Fresno
abstract	a short summary (about 200 words) of a research article, on the second page	headed *Abstract*
introduction	the first major section of the report: an opening, a literature review and a closing	begins on page 3

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
opening	the first paragraph or two: introduces the research question and explains why it is interesting	the uncomfortable smoker
literature review	a written summary of previous research on a topic; the bulk of the introduction	an argument, not a list
closing	the last paragraph or two: restates the research question and comments on the method	Darley and Latané's hypothesis
operational definition	a definition of a variable in terms of precisely how it will be measured	the number of words recalled
balanced	discussing the evidence against an idea as well as the evidence for it	studies that failed to find the effect
these considerations lead to the hypothesis that	presents the hypothesis as the result of the argument	Darley and Latané (1968, p. 378)
it is acceptable to ..., but it is not acceptable to ...	contrasts what is allowed with what is not	"... to argue that the *balance* of the research supports ..., but ... not ... to *ignore* contradictory evidence"

Rules and explanations

The ideas

Title page and abstract

- The title is centered in the upper half of the page, important words capitalized. In about 12 words or fewer it names the primary variables and research question, sometimes with a subtitle after a colon.
- Below it: the authors' names and, on the next line, their affiliation. The order of authors reflects their contribution; equal contributors are often listed alphabetically or in a random order.
- An author note (affiliations, acknowledgments, contact information) is for submitted articles; student papers, including theses, generally do not need one.
- "Cute" titles use plays on words or well-known expressions ("Time Crawls: The Temporal Resolution of Infants' Visual Attention"); some researchers use them regularly, others never.
- The abstract is on the second page, headed *Abstract*, first line not indented. In about 200 words it presents the research question, a summary of the method, the basic results and the most important conclusions.

> **APA 7th edition** (the book follows the 6th)

- Student title page: the title in **bold**; your name; department and university; course number and name; instructor; due date. There is no fixed word limit for titles, but about 12 words is still a good guide.
- A page number at the top right of every page. A running head (a short title in capitals at the top left) is needed only in professional papers, and the old label "Running head:" is no longer used.
- "Abstract" is bold and centered, usually with 250 words at most. Student papers include one only if the instructor asks (your proposal will have one).

The introduction begins on the third page under the full title (bold in the 7th edition). Its three parts usually have no headings.

The opening (a paragraph or two). Bem (2003) recommends starting with general observations about people and their behavior (not about researchers or their research), in ordinary language, often with concrete examples. Poor: "Festinger's theory of cognitive dissonance received a great deal of attention during the latter part of the 20th century". Better: a general observation (a person who holds two inconsistent beliefs may feel uncomfortable), a concrete example (a smoker who believes smoking is unhealthy), and only then the term *cognitive dissonance* and Festinger (1957). The opening then shows why the question is interesting: will the answer fill a gap in the literature, test an important theory, or have practical implications?

Breaking the rules. Humor and anecdotes are generally discouraged, but Jacoby (1999), who studied how repeated words feel familiar even when the repetitions are not recalled, opened with a story: after an orientation that kept stressing that tipping was not required, a woman with Alzheimer's disease asked only "Should I tip?" It engages the reader and is an excellent real-world example of the topic.

The literature review: an argument, not a list. By its end, readers should believe that the study is a logical next step. Possible structures:

1. a phenomenon and studies that show it; competing theories; a hypothesis to test them;
2. a phenomenon; an apparently inconsistent one; a theory that resolves the inconsistency; a hypothesis to test it;
3. (applied research) a phenomenon or theory; how it applies to a real-world situation; a way to test whether it does.

Make the structure visible: start from an outline; summarize the argument before making it ("In this article, I will describe two apparently contradictory phenomena, ..."); open each paragraph with a sentence that states its point and links it to the previous points, not with "Williams (2004) found that ...". Be balanced: include studies that failed to show the phenomenon. Uncertainty about the answer is part of what makes a question interesting.

The closing (the last paragraph or two) gives (1) the research question and hypothesis, more formally and precisely than the opening, often in terms of operational definitions, and (2) a brief overview of the method with a comment on its appropriateness. Darley and Latané (1968) state their hypothesis, then

list what a test needs: a realistic "emergency", subjects unable to communicate, and a measure of the speed and frequency of their reactions. The introduction leads smoothly into the method.

Language focus

1. Titles are noun phrases, usually without a main verb:

- *Effects of* X *on* Y: "Effects of Aging and Divided Attention on Memory for Items and Their Contexts"
- X *Differences in* Y: "Sex Differences in Coping Styles and Implications for Depressed Mood"
- Title, colon, subtitle (which may be a question): "Virtual Driving and Risk Taking: Do Racing Games Increase Risk-Taking Cognitions, Affect, and Behavior?"

2. Linking the argument

- Paragraph openings that say why a study is described: "Another example of this phenomenon comes from the work of Williams (2004)." "Williams (2004) offers one explanation of this phenomenon." "An alternative perspective has been provided by Williams (2004)." "We used a method based on the one used by Williams (2004)."
- From argument to hypothesis: "These considerations lead to the hypothesis that ..."
- *The* + comparative, *the* + comparative for a predicted relationship: "the more bystanders to an emergency, the less likely, or the more slowly, any one bystander will intervene to provide aid".

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
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> - Arabic expresses "the more ..., the less ..." with a structure built on a word meaning "whenever", so learners often write "when bystanders are more, help is less". English needs *the* and a comparative at the start of both halves.
> - If you learned to open essays with very broad statements about science or humanity, notice that Bem's "general observations" are about the behavior under study, like the uncomfortable smoker.

Practice

1. Reading questions

1. What should a title communicate, and in about how many words?
2. Which manuscripts need an author note?
3. What four things does an abstract present?
4. Why is the sentence about Festinger's theory a poor opening, according to Bem?
5. Which three questions can show why a research question is interesting?
6. Why does the book accept Jacoby's anecdote?
7. Why must a literature review be balanced?
8. What two elements does a closing contain? Find both in Darley and Latané's closing.

2. Book exercises

1. "What might be some of the pros and cons of using cute article titles?" (11.3)
2. "Practice: Look through an issue of a general interest professional journal (e.g., *Psychological Science*). Read the opening of the first five articles and rate the effectiveness of each one from 1 (*very ineffective*) to 5 (*very effective*). Write a sentence or two explaining each rating." (11.5; if you cannot open the journal, use five open-access articles from your literature search.)
3. "Practice: Find a recent article in a professional journal and identify where the opening, literature review, and closing of the introduction begin and end." (11.5)

3. Language exercise

1. Name the variables in the first two titles in Language focus 1.
2. Which of the book's paragraph openings fits each purpose? (a) a second study showing the same phenomenon; (b) a theory that explains it; (c) a competing view; (d) the source of your method.
3. Rewrite with *the* + comparative, *the* + comparative: (a) If there are more bystanders, each one is less likely to help. (b) When people see a word more often, it seems more familiar. (c) Students who sleep longer after learning remember more word pairs.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my title: [paste]. Does it name my variables in about 12 words? Suggest a version with a subtitle."
- "Read my opening as an ordinary reader: what is my research question, and why does it matter?"
- "In PSYC 110 Lecture 16 (Self and Other, Part I, Chapter 4), Professor Bloom names Festinger's theory first and then gives examples; Bem's better opening does the opposite. Discuss with me which order works better in a lecture and in a report."
- "Here is my literature review outline: [paste]. Is it an argument or a list? Where is the contradictory evidence?"

Writing task

Your research project: the title page and introduction. Begin your proposal on sleep and memory in university students (or your own topic), using your hypothesis (Lesson 05), design (Lessons 06 and 13 to 16) and sources (Lesson 33):

1. A 7th-edition student title page with a title of about 12 words that names your variables.
2. An introduction of 600 to 900 words: an opening (one paragraph that starts with people and their behavior, then says why the question is interesting); a literature review (two to four paragraphs, following one of the book's structures); a closing (the hypothesis in terms of operational definitions, such as the number of word pairs recalled out of 40 after a nap or an equal period awake, and the planned method and why it suits the question). The study has not been done yet, so the closing uses the future: "The proposed study will test ...". Leave the abstract for Lesson 37.

Self-editing checklist:

- The title names the variables, in bold title case.

- The opening begins with people and their behavior, in ordinary language, and says why the question matters.
- Each review paragraph opens with a sentence that links it to the argument.
- The review includes at least one study that does not support my hypothesis.
- The closing states the hypothesis precisely and comments on the method.
- Sources are cited correctly (Lesson 33); there is no "Introduction" heading.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. Reading questions

1. The primary variables and research questions, clearly and concisely, in about 12 words or fewer.
2. Manuscripts submitted for publication; student papers, including theses, generally do not.
3. The research question, a summary of the method, the basic results and the most important conclusions.
4. It starts with a theory and the attention researchers gave it, not with an observation about people and their behavior in ordinary language.
5. Will the answer fill a gap in the literature? Will it test an important theory? Does it have practical implications?
6. It engages the reader and is an excellent real-world example of the topic: the repeated "no tipping" made tipping feel familiar.
7. The review argues that the question is worth addressing, not that your favorite answer is right: you may argue that the *balance* of the research supports a view, but you may not *ignore* contradictory evidence.
8. (1) The hypothesis: "the more bystanders to an emergency, the less likely, or the more slowly, any one bystander will intervene to provide aid". (2) The method and its appropriateness: a realistic "emergency", subjects blocked from communicating, a measure of the speed and frequency of reactions; "The experiment reported below attempted to fulfill these conditions."

2. Book exercises

1. (example answer) Pros: a cute title catches attention and is memorable, and a subtitle can still name the variables ("Scent of a Woman: Men's Testosterone Responses to Olfactory Ovulation Cues"). Cons: it breaks the formal, straightforward tone of APA style; international readers may miss the play on words; and it may seem flippant on a serious topic. Other answers are possible.
2. (example answer) High ratings go to openings that begin with people's behavior in ordinary language, give a concrete example and quickly say why the question matters; low ratings to openings that begin with researchers or a theory, or use jargon. Ratings will differ.
3. (example answer) The opening is usually the first one or two paragraphs and ends where specific earlier studies begin; the closing often begins with a signal such as "In the present study" or "We hypothesized that".

3. Language exercise

1. Aging and divided attention (thought to affect memory) and memory for items and their contexts (the outcome); sex, coping styles and depressed mood.
2. (a) "Another example of this phenomenon comes from the work of Williams (2004)." (b) "Williams (2004) offers one explanation of this phenomenon." (c) "An alternative perspective has been provided by Williams (2004)." (d) "We used a method based on the one used by Williams (2004)."

3. (a) The more bystanders there are, the less likely each one is to help. (b) The more often people see a word, the more familiar it seems. (c) The longer students sleep after learning, the more word pairs they remember.

My notes